CHAPTER IV

Descartes and the Inception of Philosophy of Mind

He is a French philosopher who was born in Touraine in the year 1596. In addition to being a philosopher who made history, he was also a mathematician who produced innovative ideas. The term "father of modern philosophy" is another name for him. One of the most important figures in the development of modern rationality is Descartes. In the first place, he established that reason is the only factor that may decide philosophical disagreements, as was said earlier. He is the father of rationalism, which is defined by his proof that the only true, universal, and vital source of knowledge is intrinsic concepts.

René Descartes was the person who launched a revolutionary intellectual movement that was driven by a single, profound aspiration: certainty. Descartes's goal was to reconstruct knowledge from a foundational, indisputable premise during the 17th century, which was a period of intellectual transition that followed the scientific and religious upheavals that occurred during the Renaissance. He primarily expressed his approach, centred on fundamental methodological scepticism, through Meditations on First Philosophy.

Descartes's line of inquiry began with deliberate scepticism. When he was writing his Meditations on First Philosophy, he posed the question of whether anything could endure the test of radical scepticism. The sensory beliefs that we hold may be erroneous since our senses can sometimes mislead us. Because our dreams can be so similar to our waking experiences, it is possible that we are misinterpreting the world around us. When it came to mathematics and logic, he even imagined that a powerful and malevolent demon was trying to trick him. The goal that Descartes had in mind was to establish an unquestionable truth by pushing doubt to its farthest lengths.

This approach culminated in his well-known claim on the self and his steadfast, albeit controversial, thesis of mind-body dualism. In the beginning of his investigation, Descartes approached all previous knowledge with the deepest suspicion. This included both sensory experiences and logical assertions. This methodological doubt was not mere scepticism; rather, it was a tool to eliminate beliefs that could be incorrect. In reality, Descartes was the one who first introduced the concept of contemporary rationality. In the first place, he established that reason is the only person who can decide philosophical disagreements, as was said earlier. He is the father of rationalism, which is defined by his proof that the only true, universal, and vital source of knowledge is intrinsic concepts.

We owe a tremendous amount of gratitude to René Descartes for his contributions to the distinctive subfield of philosophical inquiry that is known as the philosophy of mind. Although ancient philosophers such as Plato and Aristotle engaged in intense thought over the nature of the soul, knowledge, and perception, it was Descartes who stated the mind–body issue in a manner that established the rules for contemporary argumentation. Descartes's formulation of the problem marked the beginning of the modern era of philosophical inquiry. His contributions to the development of conceptual distinctions, which continue to impact contemporary discussions in psychology, neuroscience, and advanced artificial intelligence, include his theory of substance dualism, his famous cogito, and his method of doubt. Descartes is therefore usually believed to be the individual who was responsible for laying the foundation for the contemporary philosophy of mind.

To comprehend the significance of his work, a person must first have an appreciation for the intellectual milieu in which Descartes worked. Aristotle and Christian theology were major influences on mediaeval philosophy, which held the belief that the soul was the form of the body. There wasn't a clear demarcation between the mental and physical aspects of existence, which led to a holistic understanding of human nature that integrated both dimensions in the context of mediaeval thought, emphasising the interconnectedness of the soul and body in shaping human experience and knowledge. Descartes, on the other hand, aimed to achieve certainty in knowledge by eliminating inherited biases. His objective was revolutionary; it was to reconstruct philosophy on grounds that could not be debatable.

Innate ideas: - There is no amount of sense experience that can offer us universal knowledge because the former is required and the latter is specific. As a result, the mind provides the universal principles that interpret the data received from the senses. Now that the insufficient and mediaeval expression has been removed, the theory of innate ideas actually signifies that the mind is not completely passive but is also active. It is the source of the active principles that define the formation of knowledge, such as the ability to reason, reflect, and synthesise information from experiences. Descartes' interpretation of innate ideas is mostly correct, as it is both broad and compassionate. Throughout his life, Descartes has acknowledged the dual function of intrinsic concepts. The mind is the source of consciousness, so some ideas are exclusive to it. These concepts are as follows:

1. Clearness and distinctness are characteristics that are particularly associated with the innate thoughts. In this context, the term "innate notions" referred to thoughts that were unadulterated and unrestricted.

2. Nevertheless, Descartes was compelled to broaden the concept of innateness to include ideas that are sensed as well.

First, he was unable to locate their position within the mental sequence since it appeared that they were brought about by something that was not associated with the mind. However, after that, he was forced to give in. The sensations of taste, colour, and other senses are not contained within objects; as a result, they are considered part of their physical existence. One of the most important functions of external stimuli is to serve as a release mechanism that activates the sense organs and, in turn, stimulates the pineal gland, which is responsible for creating sensory experiences, such as the perception of taste and colour, thus influencing our understanding of reality. Because of this, Descartes came to realize—albeit with some reluctance—that the concepts of sense must be inherent in the mind. According to the second perspective, the innate ideas do not constitute a distinct category; rather, the innateness of each and every concept is a quality of all ideas.

Because this cogito ergo sum is the ultimate certainty, we need to use caution while interpreting it and determining where it fits within the Cartesian philosophy. This is because the cogito ergo sum is the final certainty. It is not an inference that Descartes attempted to establish; rather, it is a straightforward truth of primal knowledge or a self-evident axiom. If the statement were an inference, it would rely solely on the premises, which would in turn rely on other premises. Continuing in this manner would result in an unending regress without ever arriving at the undeniable truth. On the other hand, the certainty of the cogito is incredibly clear and unmistakable, making it impossible for anything else to be perceived or intuited with the same level of determination. Cogito ergo sum is a philosophical principle that asserts that my consciousness is the way in which I disclose myself as something that exists. This principle highlights the undeniable reality of the inseparability of thought and existence, emphasising that my existence is confirmed through my ability to think and reflect on my own consciousness. Being conscious is the first principle, both logically and psychologically, because it implies that I am already cognisant. Given that the use of the word "therefore" led to the interpretation of the cogito as an inference, it is clear that this was a poor choice. On the other hand, the word "therefore" refers to a primary phase in the process of inference, as well as to a necessary relationship between ideas. Therefore, Descartes employs the phrase in a secondary sense with this meaning.

To maintain that thinking alone is sufficient to guarantee the existence of oneself, it is not necessary to emphasise the metaphor "I think, therefore I am." One of the most crucial things is to demonstrate that it is my consciousness that is responsible for carrying the existence of myself along with it. In addition to consciousness, there is no other function that can guarantee the existence of the self. Thus, saying "I go there because I am" is wrong, as walking with the intent to be aware can't imply self-existence.

The existence of God can be understood through concepts that are either innate or derived from a Being who is "eternal, omniscient, omnipotent, the source of all goodness and truth, the creator of all things, and, in summary, possesses within Himself all those qualities that exhibit some form of perfection, whether infinite or not limited by any imperfection." Other expressions of God's existence include.

A distinct substance, according to Descartes, is something whose existence is independent of other things. He argued that, in a definitive sense, there is only one substance, which is God. However, although God is the only uncreated substance, it is possible to acknowledge created substances. They need God's approval to exist, but they are completely independent of other created things, like accidents or modes, which means that their existence does not rely on the existence of other substances. Because uncertainty is a flawed state, he deduced that God must be a perfect being. God causes everything to happen and acts at the right time to bring harmony to the world. He wonders how we can learn about things outside ourselves, given his flaws and tendency to doubt. Most of them are the result of their own creativity, which raises the question of how these concepts can be understood if they are inherently subjective and influenced by personal doubt and imperfection. One exception to this rule is the concept of God. The concept that things are permitted by God to behave in accordance with their systems in the same manner in which they were formed was expressed by him through the phrase "divine concurrence". According to his interpretation, a flawed being cannot conceive of itself as a flawless entity since it is incapable of doing so. Since this is the case, God must be the origin of his conception of God. Since this is the case, God must exist. To this causal argument, he added a form of the ontological argument, which states that if God is a perfect being, as we conceive him to be, then he cannot lack the perfection of existence, and since everything that is real and true in an individual originates from a perfect being, the general rule that he had provisionally adopted is correct: Every one of our distinct and unmistakable thoughts must be accurate. Even thoughts that are not clear and distinct must have some basis in truth to be considered valid.

An equally perfect cause, namely the infinitely perfect being referred to as God, must have given rise to the conception of the thought. The causal argument for the presence of God is predicated on two premises:

1) Individual consciousness recognises its own limitations, and 2) this awareness of 'God' arises solely from the concept of an absolutely flawless entity.

Both assertions are based on the premise that God exists. Nonetheless, many may contend that the notion of an infinite creature is inherently pessimistic, as it lacks a definitive boundary. The idea of the infinite being is the most hopeful, according to Descartes, as it shows our limits versus the perfect being's fullness, which inspires individuals to strive for improvement and transcend their limitations.

Descartes asserts that the causal proof constitutes the cosmological proof for the existence of God. This is under the realm of ontological proof. Demonstration of this is feasible solely through the concept of a Perfect Being, which is accountable for the creation of all else in the world. Nonetheless, the most compelling proof for the existence of God is his status as an ontological being. This implies that the notion of a perfect being underlies the existence of God, analogous to how the definition of a triangle underpins the principle that the sum of its three angles equals two right angles. One cannot envision the most perfect creature without concurrently imagining Him manifesting as a tangible entity. The concept and the actual finite item are inherently interconnected. Although winged horses do not exist in reality, one can nevertheless envision them. According to Descartes, the notion of a perfect creature cannot be contemplated apart from God's existence.

Anselm's argument for the presence of God has been alleged to have been replicated by Descartes. The argument asserts that "consideration reveals the term 'God' to signify that which must be conceived as the greatest; yet, existence in actuality, as well as in conception, is beyond mere thought alone; hence, God exists not only in thought but also as the actual concept of a perfect being." "Descartes has been alleged to have plagiarised Anselm's argument. The existence of God is predicated upon the premise of His existence. The existence of God is predicated on our conception of a flawless being, which is God itself. Descartes posits that the notion of God is contingent upon His Being, so asserting that his evidence differs from that of Anselm. Descartes illustrates this differentiation by indicating that his argument is apart from Anselm's. The statement asserts, "Whatever we clearly and distinctly observe to belong to the genuine and unalterable character of everything, to its essence, its shape, that may be predicated of it." Consequently, our inquiry into God has revealed that existence constitutes an integral

aspect of His authentic and immutable essence. Consequently, we can legitimately propose the existence of God.

Mind and body

René Descartes' concept of mind and body signifies a significant transformation in comprehending the essence of the human mind, consciousness, and the interplay between mind and body. Descartes' work is regarded as the inception of the philosophy of mind, as it delineates the mind as a separate, thinking entity. It emphasises self-awareness, consciousness, and reasoning as fundamental elements of human identity. His concepts regarding cognitive processes, consciousness, and artificial intelligence persistently influence current discussions.

In his examination of the universe, Descartes differentiated between extended material, commonly referred to as matter, and thinking substance, sometimes known as the mind or soul. The defining characteristic of matter, or corporeal stuff, is its geometric expansion in length, width, and depth. A body can extend in various manners, which underpins the diverse qualities of matter, such as solid, liquid, and gas states, each exhibiting unique properties based on their geometric expansion. Conversely, each of these represents only a sort of extension. He contended that the essence of the mind is entirely incompatible with the essence of substance. Thus, the soul is entirely distinct from the body in nearly all aspects. His use of the terms 'intellect' and 'soul' was synonymous.

He posits that the mind equates to the self, the individual, and the entity responsible for thought, belief, doubt, desire, and action. The soul may persist after the body's demise, despite its incorporeal nature and lack of extension beyond the body throughout life. Descartes also claimed that souls were "simple", indicating that they lacked any constituents. His conviction that all entities in space were infinitely divisible further distinguished spirits from any substance composed of ordinary matter. This is the most significant philosophical concept that Descartes formulated, and as the principal form of dualism, it has profoundly influenced the evolution of contemporary European philosophy. Descartes believed that mental processes cannot be explained mechanically through physical attributes. Extension and thought are the essential traits that separate the two constituents of matter and mind. From his dualist perspective, a human being is not an organic unity but rather a composite of two distinct entities: the mind and the body. Nonetheless, despite this differentiation, both Aristotle and

Descartes asserted that rationality is the most essential attribute inherent to human beings from the first.

Descartes asserted that awareness constitutes the essence of the mind or the fundamental attribute of mental states, leading him to conclude that all mental states are conscious. From a Cartesian perspective, consciousness is inherently subjective, as the individual experiencing it seems to have exclusive access that others cannot achieve. This illustrates that the mind and body are two separate entities, yet they can exert causal impact on each other. Cartesian souls are independent of matter's behaviour regarding their continued existence and cognitive abilities, suggesting that they operate on a different plane of existence that is not influenced by physical laws. They do not own any spatial position, which means they exist outside the physical dimensions that govern material objects. The mind and body are distinct entities that interact beneficially throughout an individual's life. Interactionism sharply contrasts with another dualist perspective, parallelism, which refutes any causal relationship between the intellect and the body. Descartes posited the pineal gland as the locus of mind-body connection. Descartes' dualism advocated occasionalism to elucidate the relationship between the mind and the body. The mind and body, together with both corporeal and physical motions, lack a genuine causal link, which means that mental events do not directly cause physical events but rather interact through God's mediation as proposed in occasionalism. Descartes occasionally used the term "regular concurrence" to elucidate the conservation of motion in the universe, suggesting that the quantity of motion was imparted to matter at its inception.

Descartes' method for reaching the conclusion of Cogito ergo sum in the context of the mind-body conundrum is characterised by abstraction. Until he regains consciousness, he systematically discards anything that is extraneous to thought or cognition, focusing solely on the essence of his existence and the act of thinking itself. An explanation of awareness does not necessitate a reference to extension. At the same time, understanding expansion does not require invoking consciousness. Thus, consciousness, extension, mind, and body are independent and do not affect each other's existence. The mind and body are distinct entities that exist independently of each other.

The dualism between the mind and body is significant due to the human condition of possessing both a corporeal form and an immaterial essence. The human body, like all organic entities, is merely a machine. The heat focused in the core is the driving force of this machine. The individual's health has decreased due to the failure of multiple vital bodily components. God

uniquely bestows a soul solely upon human beings through a distinct act of creation. The body and spirit are inherently opposed, so a meaningful connection between them is unattainable. The connection between the soul and the body is comparable to the bond a pilot maintains with his aircraft, as both relationships require a deep understanding and respect for the distinct roles each component plays in achieving a greater purpose or function.

The relationship between the mind and the body is articulated with considerable ambiguity. We intuitively recognise a connection between mind and body; nonetheless, we must ascertain the precise nature of this relationship. Descartes oscillates between the indicated relationships and the logical parallelism arising from his strict dualism, which suggests that the mind and body are distinct yet interact in complex ways. Due to his astute observations in this domain, he is regarded as an individual who laid the foundation for contemporary behaviourism. Reflexes can elucidate a considerable portion of the physiological activities occurring within the body, demonstrating how automatic responses to stimuli can influence both physical actions and mental processes. The mind influences the body's behaviours, while the body, in turn, affects the mind, creating a complex interplay that can impact emotional and physical health, such as how stress can lead to physical symptoms like tension headaches or how physical exercise can improve mood and cognitive function. Descartes posits the existence of authentic material bodies. The veracity of the divine supports the prevalent belief in the reality of physical entities. To ascertain the ultimate certainty of specific material objects, we can only comprehend their primary qualities. The purported secondary non-quantitative features are only disordered notions, which suggests that they lack a clear and consistent basis in reality and are influenced by subjective interpretation. His elucidation of perception clearly indicates that the origins of the perplexing concepts are external to the individual. The physical body influences mental states referred to as perception.

First, body stimulation affects the sense organs of the person experiencing it.

The second reason is that this bodily compassion awakens the latent animal spirit residing inside the nerves. He posits that the pineal gland, which he considers the locus of the soul, is the terminus of the animal spirits' movement. The soul, being an indivisible substance, is in the pineal gland, the sole undivided region of the brain.

Ultimately, a physical impression or seal is left on the pineal gland, the site where consciousness initially originates.

Plato was recognised as the progenitor of philosophy, positing that the soul is separate from the body. This idea has been examined throughout philosophical history; however, Descartes

is commonly considered the progenitor of the contemporary mind-body problem. René Descartes is frequently regarded as the preeminent proponent of dualism in modern philosophy. Cartesian dualism is the doctrine for which Descartes is most renowned. He advocates a perspective of the mind as a separate substance from the body, characterised by unique, essential, or distinguishing attributes. Moreover, he contends that the mind can exist independently of the body and possesses a distinct identity that sets it apart from other minds. Descartes made a substantial contribution by redefining the distinction between the mind or soul and the body, as well as between the corporeal and the incorporeal. Prior to Descartes, the incorporeal mind was often regarded as equivalent to the intellect. Conversely, Descartes delineated our modern conception of the mind as embracing a broader spectrum, including sensation, perception, imagination, and emotion. Descartes was the inaugural individual to propose a resolution to the mind-body dilemma in the contemporary period. He concluded that ideas are entirely distinct from both bodies and all physical objects. Proponents of Cartesian dualism assert that minds are fundamentally spiritual and inherently non-spatial, implying that they lack both size and location. This perspective posits that a typical human being embodies dualism, consisting of both a mind and a body in unity. The mind and body lack a spatial link; the mind exists as an autonomous entity. A causal relationship exists between the mind and the body, notwithstanding their fundamental distinction. Physiological events elicit sensations, experiences, and thoughts in the mind, whereas mental processes provoke actions and speech, subsequently resulting in the physical movements of limbs or lips. Cartesian dualism possesses significant intuitive allure, and Descartes's "first-person" or "internal" viewpoint has prevailed in the domain of philosophy of mind.

Descartes dismissed the methodologies and assumptions of scholasticism and sought to construct knowledge on a firm foundation by demanding perfect assurance in the validation of our concepts. The cornerstone of his philosophical methodology was systematic doubt, which rejected any assertion as real unless it could be distinctly and definitely verified as true. He employed this strategy to eradicate biases and preconceived beliefs, aiming to provide a robust and stable conceptual foundation for his philosophy. He recognised that the primary, indisputable truth pertains to all individuals: "I think; therefore, I exist." I think, therefore I am. This statement represents one of the essential concepts that underlie Descartes's metaphysical philosophy. The existence of my body is one of numerous questions I can pose. My existence, however, is dependent on my engagement in the act of thinking. Despite my uncertainty about my own existence, there must be an "I" capable of harbouring such concerns. Descartes devised

the method of doubt to address scepticism and uncover undeniable truth. Doubt can be employed as a mechanism to redirect the mind from sensory perceptions to intellectual truths. "Cogito ergo sum", translating to "I think, therefore I am", was the phrase he employed to convey this certainty. Even if the devil succeeded in deceiving him regarding the nature of his ideas, it was undeniable that the "I" involved in thinking existed. Consequently, the res cogitans, sometimes referred to as the mind, emerged as the primary dependable source of information. The essence of "I" was entirely characterised by thought, regardless of any physical form or external reality. Descartes arrived at his famous conclusion by methodically doubting his existence as a thinking being, which provided evidence of that existence.

An exhaustive examination of the significance of the phrase "cogito ergo sum" in Cartesian philosophy is crucial, as it represents the pinnacle of certainty. Descartes aimed to resolve this issue by claiming that it is not an inference but a fundamental fact of primary knowledge or a self-evident axiom. If it were an inference, its certainty would depend exclusively on the premises, which would, in turn, require other premises for their assurance of certainty. Utilising this method would lead to an endless regression without achieving an unequivocal truth, as each premise would necessitate further premises, ultimately preventing any definitive conclusion from being reached. The Cogito's certainty is clear, and no other reality can be known with such certainty. My consciousness acts as the medium via which I affirm my being, and the phrase "Cogito Ergo Sum" encapsulates this idea. The indissoluble connection between thought and existence is an undeniable truth. The fundamental principle, viewed from both intellectual and psychological perspectives, is that my existence is related to my consciousness as the reality. The use of the term "therefore" unfortunately led to the interpretation of the cogito as an inference, which was a negative outcome. In contrast, the phrase "therefore" primarily signifies a phase in the inference process while also suggesting an essential relationship connection. Descartes used the phrase "therefore" in a subordinate context.

It is inappropriate to underscore the phrase "I think, therefore I am" to suggest that mere thought suffices to affirm one's existence. A crucial issue is to furnish evidence that my consciousness embodies my existence. Aside from consciousness, no function can ensure the existence of the self. Consequently, it is erroneous to assert, "I walk; therefore, I am," as walking devoid of consciousness cannot signify self-existence. This is due to the fact that walking is a physical activity.

Another variant of substance dualism, commonly referred to as substantial or substantival dualism, is the dualist viewpoint on individuals that Descartes formulated. Descartes classified

substances into two categories: extensive substances, which pertain to matter, and thinking substances, which pertain to the mind or soul. A distinguishing attribute of matter, also referred to as corporeal material, is its geometric expansion in length, width, and depth. Matter is distinguished by its various attributes, one of which is a body's capacity to grow in several dimensions. Conversely, each of them is really an extension of its predecessor. He contended that the nature of the mind is entirely distinct from the nature of substance. From this viewpoint, the soul is entirely separate from the body. He employed the terms "mind" and "soul" synonymously in his discourse. He regards the mind as equivalent to the self, the person, and the essence that governs thinking, believing, doubting, desiring, and doing. The soul is immaterial, non-physical, and able to persist beyond the body's demise, even if it unites with the body during existence. Descartes contended that spirits are "simple", signifying that they lack any constituents. His view that all entities in space are infinitely divisible distinguished souls from ordinary matter. This is the paramount philosophical notion formulated by Descartes, and due to its status as the most essential kind of dualism, it has profoundly impacted modern European philosophy. Descartes contended that mental phenomena cannot be elucidated mechanically through physical attributes. The fundamental attributes of the two entities are extension and thought, as these define the essence of both matter and mind. His dualist approach posits that a human being is not an organic totality but a composite of two separate entities: the mind and the body. Both Aristotle and Descartes claimed that rationality is the quintessential attribute of humanity, notwithstanding their divergent perspectives.

Let us put down the major tenets of Cartesian substance dualism:

1. There exist two fundamentally distinct categories of substances: mental substances, including minds, and material substances, comprising bodies. The fundamental characteristic of a mind is to think, possess consciousness, and participate in various cognitive processes; the essence of a body is to occupy space and have physical dimensions.
2. A human being is a composite being (a "union", as Descartes called it) of mind and body.
3. Minds differ from bodies; no mind is identical to a body.

Descartes's philosophy of mind is distinguished from the philosophical perspectives of his contemporaries, such as Leibniz, Malebranche, and Spinoza, by his deeply pragmatic belief in the causal interplay between minds and bodies. My thirst compelled me to grasp a glass of water, exemplifying how the mind guides the body towards the appropriate action in executing a deliberate task. In the domain of perception, the principle of causality operates inversely: when we perceive a tree, the tree induces a visual experience akin to that of a tree. The experience of encountering a tree is markedly different from merely visualising or hallucinating

it. Consequently, we shall now present the next argument regarding the relationship between the mind and the body:

4. The minds and the bodies rely on one another for causal influence. It is possible for certain mental occurrences to be the cause of physical events, and vice versa.

Emphasising that consciousness constitutes the essence of the mind or the fundamental characteristic of mental states, Descartes concluded that all mental states are conscious. From a Cartesian perspective, consciousness is inherently subjective, as the individual experiencing it seems to have exclusive access that is unavailable to others. This illustrates that the mind and body, although separate entities, can exert causal impact on one another. Cartesian souls are independent of material behaviour because of their capacity to reason and their continued existence, which suggests that they can influence physical actions and decisions despite not owning any spatial position. They do not own any spatial position.

The mind and body are distinct entities that engage in mutually beneficial interactions throughout an individual's life. Interactionism sharply contrasts with another dualist perspective, parallelism, which rejects any causal relationship between the mind and body. Descartes posited the pineal gland as the locus of mind-body connection. To elucidate the relationship between the mind and body, Descartes introduced the concept of occasionalism, which contradicted his dualist viewpoint. The mind and body, together with both corporeal and physical motions, lack a genuine causal link. Descartes occasionally used the term "regular concurrence" to elucidate the conservation of motion, suggesting that the quantity of motion was imparted to matter at its inception.

Descartes characterises a separate substance as one whose existence is independent from that of other substances. He further claimed that, in a strict sense, there exists just one material, which is God. Although God is the only uncreated substance, it is feasible to identify created substances. This arises from their reliance on divine approval for their being but also maintaining independence from other created entities, such as accidents or modes. Considering that doubt is a flawed condition, he concluded that God is an immaculate being. To sustain equilibrium, God orchestrates every event and intervenes at the most opportune moment, ensuring that the universe operates in a harmonious balance that reflects His immaculate nature. In light of his nature as a cynic and an imperfect being, he questions how humans may have acquired knowledge that transcends his understanding, particularly considering the vast array of experiences and insights that individuals gain throughout their lives. Most of these ideas

result from individual creation. The notion of God, conversely, constitutes an exception to this principle. He employed the term "divine concurrence" to express the perspective that God allows entities to function according to their intrinsic systems as intended. He argues that a defective being cannot independently conceive the notion of a perfect existence. Consequently, it follows that God must be the origin of his understanding of God. Consequently, the existence of God is unequivocally essential. Alongside this causal argument, he articulated a variant of the ontological argument, positing that if God is a perfect being, as commonly conceived, then he must embody the perfection of existence, with all that is real and true in a person deriving from a perfect being. He indeed adopted the interim rule, which asserts that all of our distinct and unequivocal thoughts must be accurate. Regarding truth, even perplexing and ambiguous opinions must possess some foundation in reality.

The inception of this discipline in contemporary times inextricably links René Descartes's contributions to the philosophy of mind. In doing so, he directed philosophy towards the inner realm of consciousness and established the mind as a central object of systematic inquiry. He accomplished this by instilling confidence in the rational self, which allowed individuals to trust their own reasoning and introspection as valid sources of knowledge. His differentiation between thinking substance and extending substance offered subsequent philosophers an alternative paradigm for exploring perception, knowledge, identity, and the relationship between mental and physical phenomena, which allowed for a more profound understanding of how these concepts interact and influence one another in philosophical discourse.

Despite their rejection of Cartesian dualism, philosophers persist in grappling with the challenges it presents, including the connection between subjective experience and the body, the feasibility of mental causation, and the notion of selfhood. We can interpret materialism, behaviourism, and functionalism as responses to or modifications to Descartes' original challenge. These hypotheses are not considered deviations from Descartes' initial challenge.

Consequently, Descartes' enduring contribution lies not solely in the solutions he provided but in the framework he constructed. Although he established a conceptual framework, the fundamental issues of current discourse regarding consciousness and cognition persist within that framework, indicating that his ideas, while foundational, do not fully resolve the complexities and debates surrounding these topics today, such as the mind-body problem and the nature of subjective experience. Consequently, he remains a pivotal character, whose influence is evident in all studies of the nature of the mind.

The emergence of artificial intelligence in the twentieth century reintroduced Cartesian dilemmas, albeit in a transformed manner. Can a machine possess the capacity for thought if it is defined as the essence of the mind? Is it feasible to synthetically replicate abilities such as reasoning, problem-solving, or language use? Researchers, such as Alan Turing, redefined the issue by establishing behavioural criteria for intelligence. Turing's inquiry was not about whether a machine had an immaterial mind; instead, he questioned if a machine's performance is indistinguishable from that of a human interlocutor. This action shifts the emphasis from the intrinsic essence to the external function, highlighting the importance of observable behaviour over internal mental states when evaluating machine intelligence.

Functionalist philosophers contend that mental states are characterised not by the substance of a system's composition but by the functions they perform within it. In theory, can silicon have pain, belief, or desire analogous to biological entities? In this context, functionalism embodies both a response to Descartes and an evolution of his concepts, suggesting that mental states, such as pain, belief, or desire, can be understood in terms of their functional roles rather than their physical substrates. Although it dismisses immaterial stuff, it upholds the notion that the mental is not synonymous with any particular physical element.

Nonetheless, Descartes remains a subject of discourse in the realm of artificial intelligence, especially concerning consciousness and subjectivity. Would a machine that reproduces human behaviour in every detail still be deemed to possess experience? What is the experience of being integrated into that system to some extent? These problems exemplify the Cartesian notion that the essence of the mind is first-person awareness, a phenomenon challenging to articulate externally. Opponents of advanced artificial intelligence often allude, either implicitly or explicitly, to this legacy, suggesting that AI lacks the first-person awareness that characterises human consciousness and thus cannot truly replicate human thought or experience.

In addition, the emphasis that Descartes placed on certainty and rational transparency stands in stark contrast to understandings of cognition that are widespread today. Recent research in psychology and artificial intelligence has illuminated the importance of unconscious processing, heuristics, and tactile interaction with the environment, suggesting that these factors play a crucial role in decision-making and problem-solving, which challenges Descartes' view of cognition as primarily rational and conscious. Thought may not be as distinct, clear, or cognitively superior as Descartes conceived. Nonetheless, these adjustments are discernible when contrasted with his innovative structure.

René Descartes is regarded as the progenitor of the philosophy of mind because he articulated the essential enquiries deemed most significant: the essence of the self, the interplay between mental and physical realities, and the legitimacy of conscious awareness. The use of artificial intelligence (AI) elevates these enquiries into the domain of technology, prompting the question of whether cognition necessitates a soul, a brain, or only the appropriate arrangement of processes. Descartes was the inaugural figure to delineate the context for the discourse, irrespective of one's alignment with dualism, materialism, or computational theories.

Demonstrate what you obtained

1 Describe the concept thesis of mind-body dualism

Descartes' dualist perspective on individuals is a variant of substance dualism, often referred to as substantial or substantival dualism. Descartes categorised the world into two types of substances: extended substance, which refers to matter, and thinking substance, which refers to the mind or soul.

2 Describe the notion ‘Cogito Ergo Sum'

"I am thinking; therefore, I exist." (cogito ergo sum) The first principle, or first truth, of Descartes’s metaphysical system. I can doubt everything, including whether I have a body. But as long as I am engaged in the process of thinking, I exist.

Knock your Brain

1--------- generally referred to as the Father of Modern Philosophy.

(René Descartes, Alan Turing, John Searle, Plato)

2 who laid down that reason is the sole arbiter of philosophical dispute.

(René Descartes, Alan Turing, John Searle, Plato)

3------ is the founder of rationalism

(Alan Turing, John Searle, Plato, Descartes)

4 ---------- is considered the father of the modern mind-body problem.

(Alan Turing, John Searle, Plato, Descartes)

5----------is a subfield of ethics that focusses on the practical application of ethical concepts

(Truth, Correspondence, Justification Applied ethics)

Unleash your potential

1 What does Descartes mean by mind–body dualism?

2 Elucidate Descartes' assertion "Cogito, ergo sum."

3 What distinguishes mind (res cogitans) from body (res extensa) in Descartes' philosophy?

4. What was Descartes' contribution to the evolution of the philosophy of mind?